

Twelve signs a seawall is failing

What to look for, where to look for it, and what it means when you find it.

WALK THE WALL • 20 MINUTES

How to use this

Walk the full length of your wall twice: once from the land side at any tide, and once from the water or a dock at the lowest tide you can catch. Low tide is when a wall tells the truth. Photograph anything you tick, from the same spot each time, so you can see whether it is moving.

1 Sinkholes or soft ground behind the wall

A depression, a soft patch or a void in the lawn, patio or driveway near the wall. It usually means soil is escaping through the wall into the water, which hollows out the ground you are standing on long before anything looks wrong from the water side.

2 Cracks in the cap

Hairline cracks are common. Cracks you can fit a coin into, cracks that run through the full depth, or cracks that have opened wider since you last looked are not.

3 Gaps opening between panels

Panels are meant to sit tight against each other. A visible gap, or a line of daylight at low tide, is a path for soil to leave.

4 Water or sand coming through the joints

Sand fanning out below a joint at low tide, or water seeping through on a falling tide, is soil loss in progress. This is the clearest single sign a wall is actively failing.

5 A wall that leans, bows or has gone out of line

Sight along the top of the cap from one end. A straight wall reads straight. Bowing outward at the middle of a run usually points to tieback or anchor trouble behind it.

6 Panels out of alignment with their neighbours

One panel standing proud of the next, or rotated relative to it, means something has moved that was not supposed to.

7 Rust stains and spalling concrete

Brown staining bleeding out of the concrete means the steel inside is corroding. Corroding steel expands, and expanding steel breaks the concrete off from the inside. Spalled patches with bar visible are well advanced.

- 8 Weep holes blocked or missing**
Weep holes let water pressure out from behind the wall. Blocked with debris, or never installed, and the wall carries a load it was not designed for every time it rains.
- 9 Settlement at the base of the wall**
Pavers, a pool deck or a slab dipping towards the wall is the same soil-loss story as a sinkhole, read from the surface.
- 10 Vegetation growing in the joints or the cap**
Roots open cracks and hold water against the concrete. A seedling in a joint is a small problem now and a split panel in a few years.
- 11 Erosion at the toe, on the water side**
Scour at the base of the wall takes away the material holding it in place. It is easiest to see at an exceptionally low tide.
- 12 A neighbour's wall failing at the property line**
Walls carry load across a boundary. A failure next door frequently becomes a failure at your end of the run, and whose it is becomes an expensive argument.

What a tick means. One item on its own is worth watching. Two or more, or any sign of soil leaving the property, is worth a professional look now rather than at the end of the season. This sheet is a screening aid for owners, not an engineering inspection, and it cannot tell you what a wall needs or what it will cost.